HCP 992 (cpc_1903-12-04_DE_Munchen_DE_Eschersheim_kellermann-02): a love card from Erich to Margarethe Kellermann

Human solver: Tomáš Pavuk

Status: deciphered in full (111 of 111 cipher signs); one cipher word (GUNKTE) and one plain word ("Herrn"?) are uncertain, and one word was inked out by the writer. Independent review 1 verdict ACCEPT, no change to the reading. Report dated 2026-11-03.

Origin and context

The cryptogram is record 992 of the HC Portal (https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/992), portal name cpc_1903-12-04_DE_Munchen_DE_Eschersheim_kellermann-02, part of Tobias Schrödel's collection of cryptographic postcards (private collection). When it was captured on 2026-11-03 the portal listed it as **Not solved**, tagged Postcard and T. Schrödel Collection, language Unknown, sender Unknown, recipient Margarethe Kellermann, with no transcription or solution attached.

It is a picture postcard of the Frauenkirche in Munich, dated on the picture side "München 4. Dez. 03." (4 December 1903). The address side is in plain writing: **Fräulein Margarethe Kellermann / p/Adr. Herrn A. Weyhe / Hochwohlgeboren / Eschersheim b/Frankfurt a/Main / Frankfurterstr. 49.** The postmarks are München and the arrival mark Eschersheim 5.12.03, which agrees with the written date.

The message on the picture side mixes ordinary German Kurrent handwriting (the practical news) with lines in a cipher of digits and a few invented signs (the endearments, the closing and one word in a parenthesis). The language is German. A sister card, HCP 993 (same writer, same recipient, München, February 1903), uses the same key and the same phrases ("Mein herzinniggeliebtes Herzens....!", "Bin kerngesund", "Dich aber umarmt … Dein Erich") and is signed "Erich".



Picture side (source/picture-large.jpg)

Address side (source/address-large.jpg)

The address side carries no cipher. The stamp is on the address side, placed diagonally, and has not been lifted. No writing is visible at its edges, in the picture or along the borders. Because some cards in this collection hide a message under the stamp, the area under this stamp is listed below as not

inspected.

Method

The transcription is manual and is the solver's own. The cipher lines were read sign by sign from enlarged crops of the un-converted high-resolution scan, and the red channel was used to suppress the grey collection watermark. The key was recovered from a crib. The pattern 3 4 i 2 / 8 4 r I … at the start of the card fits "MEIN HERZ…", and the long word that follows, with its doubled 2 2 and 9 9, fits "HERZINNIGGELIEBTES". This gives E N M I H R Z G L B T S. The remaining letters A Ä C D K U Ü followed from UND, KUSSEN, GRÜSSEN, UNZÄHLIGEN, SICH, NACH, DIR, SEHNENDES and DICH ABER UMARMT. The key was then checked against the sister card HCP 993 and agrees with it in every shared letter.

The reviewer, a separate Claude Opus 5.5 agent, made its own crops, read every cipher sign again, wrote its own sign names and key, and decoded them with its own script. Its output was identical in all positions.

Key

Monoalphabetic substitution, one sign per letter, no homophones. The labels are names for the handwritten shapes.

Sign	Plain	Sign	Plain
1	L	2	N
3	M	4	E
5	S	6	B
7	T	8	H
9 (open loop)	G	φ-like sign: 9 with a filled oval loop on a long descender	A
the same with two dots	Ä	V-shaped sign	D
capital-I-like sign	Z	arch with a dot under it	I
hook like a reversed c	C	tall stroke with a hook (open 6)	R
double-crossed sign (like ‡)	K	U-shaped sign	U
U-shaped sign with two dots	Ü		

F, J, O, P, Q, V, W, X, Y and ß do not occur on this card. HCP 993 adds signs for some of them, for example + for F and 0 for O. The card has 111 cipher signs in all.

Ciphertext and plaintext

The cipher lines as transcribed. Sign names are as above; i. = the dotted arch, A9 = the A sign, c = the C hook, r = the R hook, 2* = the last sign of the signature.

```
C1: 3 4 i. 2 / 8 4 r I i. 2 2 i. 9 9 4 1 i. 4 6 - 7 4 5 / 8 4 r I 4 2 5 [BLOT] .... !
C2: 9 U 2 K 7 4
C3: V i. c 8 / A9 6 4 r / U 3 A9 r 3 7
C4: 3 i. 7 / U 2 I A9: 8 1 i. 9 4 2 / 9 r U: 5 5 4 2 / U 2 V / K U 5 5 4 2 / V 4 i. 2 / 5 i. c 8 /
    5 4 8 r / 2 A9 c 8 / V i. r / 5 4 8 2 4 2 V 4 5 / 4 r i. c 2* ..... ....
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The whole card in German. Deciphered parts are in capitals; the plain Kurrent parts are in normal case.

München 4. Dez. 03. MEIN HERZINNIGGELIEBTES HERZENS [word inked out by the writer] ….! (hatte dir GUNKTE [= Punkte?] aufgeschrieben) Wollte dir noch schnell mitteilen, daß

du Herrn(?) zum 7. gratulierst, habe versehentlich der letzten Karte u. Paket falsche Adresse gegeben, bin kerngesund. Morgen schreibe ich Brief. Grüße bitte alle Lieben recht herzlich. DICH ABER UMARMT MIT UNZÄHLIGEN GRÜSSEN UND KUSSEN [= Küssen] DEIN SICH SEHR NACH DIR SEHNENDES ERIC[H] ....

English translation: **Munich, 4 Dec. 03. My most dearly beloved heart's [inked-out word]....! (I had written you "dots"?) I wanted to quickly tell you that you should congratulate Mr(?) on the 7th; by mistake I gave the wrong address on the last card and parcel; I am perfectly healthy. Tomorrow I will write a letter. Please give my warmest regards to all the dear ones. But you are embraced, with countless greetings and kisses, by your Erich, who longs for you very much ....**

Slovak translation: **Mníchov, 4. dec. 03. Moje najvrúcnejšie milované srdiečko [začiernené slovo]....! (napísal som ti „bodky"?) Chcel som ti ešte rýchlo oznámiť, že máš 7. zablahoželať pánovi(?); omylom som na poslednej pohľadnici a balíku uviedol nesprávnu adresu; som úplne zdravý. Zajtra napíšem list. Pozdravuj, prosím, srdečne všetkých milých. Ale objíma ťa s nespočetnými pozdravmi a bozkami tvoj po tebe veľmi túžiaci Erich ....**

Reproduction

From the repository root:

```
python3 -I ciphers/hcp-992/work/decode.py
```

The script uses only the Python standard library. It checks the SHA-256 hashes of the four scans and applies the key to the manual transcription in work/transcription.txt. It then prints the four decoded cipher lines, the count "cipher tokens: 111" and the whole card text. It does not read the image. The transcription step is manual and was confirmed independently in review.

Uncertainties

- **Inked-out word** after HERZENS: the writer covered it with a solid ink bar. It cannot be recovered.
- **GUNKTE** (parenthesis): the key gives G U N K T E, which is not a German word. "Punkte" (dots) fits the context, because this couple's cards end greetings with rows of dots ("Herzens....!", "Erich ....."). That reading would mean the writer used the G sign where P was needed. P is attested neither here nor on HCP 993. The word is reported literally.
- **Signature**: E R I C, then a last sign with a filled blob over a lower loop. It may be a 2 (N) with a blob or a cramped 8 (H) with this writer's filled upper loop. It is read as H ("Erich") on word sense and because HCP 993 is signed "Erich" with a plain 8. It is printed ERIC[H].
- **Faint signs**: in UMARMT the 2nd sign lies under the collection watermark (3, read M), and the 3rd is the A sign with a partly filled loop. The first sign of DIR is faint (D). The second dotted arch in HERZINNIG has a tick instead of a dot (read I). KUSSEN has no umlaut dots and is kept as written. In GRÜSSEN the two dots stand somewhat high but are read as Ü.
- **Plain Kurrent**: the word after "daß du" is uncertain ("Herrn"?: a capital H, short letters, a superscript hook, n). "kerngesund" and "versehentlich" rest partly on word sense. The rest reads.
- "sehnendes" (neuter) before a male name is as written.
- The area under the postage stamp was not inspected, because the stamp is not lifted.
- The writer is known only by his first name, Erich. The person to be congratulated is not identified.

Review summary

Reviewer: Claude Opus 5.5 (Anthropic), a separate agent, round 1, verdict **ACCEPT**. The reviewer:

- ran the reproduction command;
- read all cipher signs independently from its own enlargements and decoded them with its own script (identical output, 111 tokens, 20 key entries, no conflicts);

- checked the A/G, R/B and K signs against each other and against HCP 993;
- confirmed the reading of the plain Kurrent;
- found no cipher or hidden writing on the address side or along the picture.

It made five minor findings. What changed:

- **Signature sign**: it may be a cramped 8. The name is now printed ERIC[H], with HCP 993 cited.
- **Letter count**: corrected from "about 140" to 111 cipher signs. The script now prints the count.
- **GUNKTE**: the possible G-for-P slip is now stated.
- **A sign**: the description now cross-refers to HCP 993 (oval crossed by a long vertical, φ).
- **Address**: "Hochwohlgeboren" added.

No decoded letter changed as a result of the review. The steganography check (stamp, picture, edges) found nothing, so the cipher type stays MASC.

Sources

- HC Portal record 992, General, Description and Attachments tabs, captured 2026-11-03: https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/992 (source/metadata.md). Linked reference: https://ecp.ep.liu.se/index.php/histocrypt/article/view/166
- Picture side: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3036/conversions/cpc_1903-12-04_DE_Munchen_DE_Eschersheim_kellermann-02_pic-large.jpg (source/picture-large.jpg). The original resolution is in work/hires/.
- Address side: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3037/conversions/cpc_1903-12-04_DE_Munchen_DE_Eschersheim_kellermann-02_adr-large.jpg (source/address-large.jpg). The original resolution is in work/hires/.
- Sister card HCP 993 in this repository (ciphers/hcp-993): same writer, same key.
- A web search on 2026-11-03 found no published solution of this card, and the AI Decipherment Register had no entry for it.